

The North Australian Savannas

A diverse tropical grassland of two seasonal extremes, home to hundreds of native plant and animal species



North Australia's grassland is one of the world's largest remaining tropical savannas and shares much in common with those of Africa. However, where Africa's savannas have large grazing animals, insects such as termites eat much of the plant material in Australia's savannas, alongside marsupials ranging from the small short-beaked echidna to large red kangaroos. Waterfowl,

wading birds, and reptiles live in the wetter parts of the region, and the Cape York Peninsula alone contains around 60 percent of Australia's butterfly species.

Due to its midlatitude location, the grassland is subject to the El Niño Southern Oscillation climate cycle. This produces a pattern of high rainfall and drought that gives the area its two contrasting seasons.

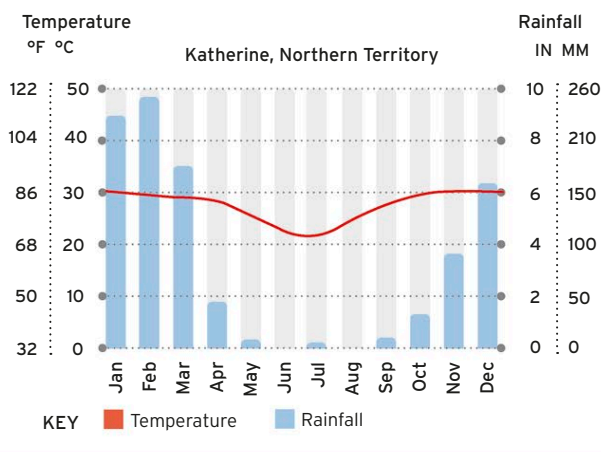


◀ DESIGNED TO RUN

At up to 7 ft (2.1m) high, the emu is the savanna's—and Australia's—largest bird. It cannot fly, but long, powerful legs enable it to run at speeds up to 30 mph (48 kph).

CLIMATE

Australia's savannas have two distinct seasons. During the hot, humid wet season (December–March), northwesterly winds blow in heavy rainstorms. From May to October, the dry season sets in, with low temperatures and humidity.



△ PERFECTLY ADAPTED PALM

Highly drought-resistant *Livistona* palms can cope with seasonal extremes because they are able to survive frequent fires, as well as heavy downpours.

▽ MAGNETIC MOUNDS

The magnetic or compass termite builds impressive mounds 10–12 ft (3–4 m) high. The wedge-shaped structures are constructed so that their longest sides are aligned north-south, keeping them cool.

Giant grazing animals roamed the savannas about 40,000 years ago

